

Rushdie & Roy: people-first guided exercises

Private practice for Hana and Aiden

This version puts character description first: eyes, smiles, mouths, posture, silence, voice, clothes and the private worlds people carry. Each page explains the literary move, shows one model answer, and leaves space for a new answer.

Rule: borrow the method, not the exact words. Use normal English words and make the person memorable.

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1. Eyes: choose the exact image

"gemstone eyes: tiger's-eyes"

Salman Rushdie, *Midnight's Children* (1981)

Plain English

This is character description that does not stop at colour. The eyes become valuable, bright and slightly animal. A good eye image should suggest temperament as well as appearance.

The task

Describe a character's eyes with one precise image. The image must also hint at the person's nature.

Model answer

Amira had storm-glass eyes: clear while she listened, darkening the moment she decided you were lying.

Why it works

The eyes are not only blue, brown or green. The storm-glass image suggests intelligence, change and danger.

Now you try

Write three eye descriptions. Make one kind, one secretive and one frightening. Use real, ordinary words.

2. Smile: make it an object

"portable piano smile"

Arundhati Roy, *The God of Small Things* (1997)

Plain English A smile can be more than happy. Roy turns it into an object that can be carried around. The piano image also makes the smile feel arranged, polished and unsettling.

The task Give a character a smile that works like an object. Do not write 'nice smile' or 'evil smile'.

Model answer Mr Vale opened a sealed-envelope smile, thin at the edges and impossible to trust.

Why it works The smile becomes something closed and deliberate. The reader feels suspicion without being told what to think.

Now you try

Write three smiles: one generous, one fake and one dangerous.

3. Smile: make it a biography

"His only luggage"

Arundhati Roy, *The God of Small Things* (1997)

Plain English	The smile is treated like something carried from childhood into adult life. That is powerful because one detail suddenly contains a whole biography.
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The task	Choose one feature and make it something the character has carried for years.
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Model answer	Grandma still carried her playground grin, chipped at the edges but unmistakably hers.
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Why it works	The grin tells us about age, memory and character. It feels old without being dead.
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Now you try

Describe one adult feature as something carried from childhood: a laugh, scar, frown, habit, voice or way of walking.

4. Mouth: show the feeling before speech

"trying-not-to-cry mouth"

Arundhati Roy, *The God of Small Things* (1997)

Plain English	The mouth reveals what the person is trying to hide. This is stronger than simply writing 'she was upset'.
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The task	Describe a mouth, jaw, chin or throat that betrays an emotion before the character speaks.
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Model answer	Sam's brave mouth wobbled before his voice did.
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Why it works	The word 'brave' shows the effort. The wobble shows the truth. One body detail does the emotional work.
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Now you try

Write four sentences: one for grief, one for anger, one for panic and one for relief.

5. Face: frame the important detail

"a cushioned setting"

Salman Rushdie, *Midnight's Children* (1981)

Plain English	Rushdie describes the face as a setting for the eyes. That teaches an excellent move: the whole face can frame one important detail.
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The task	Make the face a frame, stage or setting for the feature that matters most.
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Model answer	Her round face was a quiet frame for eyes that missed nothing.
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Why it works	The sentence guides the reader's attention. We know which detail matters and what it says about her.
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Now you try

Describe a face that frames one feature: eyes, mouth, eyebrows, scar, cheeks or nose.

6. Past: put history on the body

"handcuffed to history"

Salman Rushdie, *Midnight's Children* (1981)

Plain English

This does not mean literal handcuffs. It means the past has power over the person. Family history, reputation, old promises or old mistakes can feel as if they are holding the character's wrists.

The task

Make an invisible pressure feel physical. Do not write only 'he felt trapped'. Show what is trapping him.

Model answer

Mina walked into school with her father's unfinished promise dragging at her ankles.

Why it works

The sentence turns a promise into something heavy that follows the body. We feel the pressure before we know the whole story.

Now you try

Write one sentence about a child trapped by family expectation, a promise, a rumour or an old mistake.

7. Inner life: a whole world inside

"swallow a world"

Salman Rushdie, *Midnight's Children* (1981)

Plain English	The phrase suggests that one person can contain a huge amount: memories, places, languages, loyalties, fears and secrets. To understand the person, you almost have to enter the world inside them.
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The task	Show that a character is complicated by giving them a hidden inner world.
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Model answer	To understand Leila, you had to cross the city she carried inside: the bakery smell, the shouting buses, the sea wind she missed.
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Why it works	The answer avoids saying 'Leila was complicated'. It gives details that make her inner life visible.
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Now you try

Write three sentences beginning with: To understand him/her, you had to...

8. Personality: turn a trait into an illness

"optimism as a disease"

Salman Rushdie, *Midnight's Children* (1981)

Plain English

Rushdie often makes large ideas feel bodily. A trait can spread, itch, ache, stain or press on a character. This makes personality visible.

The task

Choose one abstract noun and make it act on a character's body.

Model answer

Guilt pressed its thumb into Josh's throat whenever the teacher asked who had broken the window.

Why it works

Guilt becomes a hand. The pressure in the throat also shows why Josh cannot speak easily.

Now you try

Write four sentences. Use one of these nouns: guilt, pride, jealousy, ambition, homesickness, duty.

9. Silence: show what is not said

"Big Things lurk unsaid inside"

Arundhati Roy, *The God of Small Things* (1997)

Plain English

The sentence makes silence feel crowded. Important thoughts are not spoken, but they are still present, hiding inside people.

The task

Show what a character is not saying.

Model answer

At dinner, Nora asked for salt, passed the bread, and kept the apology locked behind her teeth.

Why it works

The ordinary actions cover the important feeling. The locked apology shows what is being held back.

Now you try

Write four sentences where someone says something small while hiding something important.

10. Change: let a day alter the face

"Things can change in a day"

Arundhati Roy, *The God of Small Things* (1997)

Plain English	This sentence is about sudden change. For character writing, the useful question is: how does one day leave a mark on the body?
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The task	Show that a character has been changed by one day without explaining the whole event.
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Model answer	By home time, the boy who had arrived with polished shoes and neat hair looked older around the eyes.
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Why it works	The sentence begins with ordinary appearance, then shows the change through the face.
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Now you try

Write three before-and-after sentences about a child changed by one day.

11. Posture: choose an adverb with shape

"fatly baffled in the sun"

Arundhati Roy, *The God of Small Things* (1997)

Plain English	The adverb makes confusion look physical. The aim is not to invent nonsense words. The aim is to choose a normal word that changes the body's shape or posture.
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The task	Show a feeling through how the character stands, moves or speaks.
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Model answer	He stood stiffly cheerful in the doorway, smiling too hard at everyone.
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Why it works	The word 'stiffly' shows the smile is not relaxed. The reader senses discomfort without being told exactly what he feels.
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Now you try

Write four sentences using normal adverbs such as stiffly, heavily, sharply, awkwardly, proudly, slowly or weakly.

12. Voice: make sound reveal character

Plain English	A voice can show class, confidence, fear, age, cruelty or kindness. It should not be a label. It should feel like something we can hear.
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The task	Describe a voice before you explain the person's personality.
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Model answer	Her voice came out polished and tiny, like a silver spoon shut in a drawer.
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Why it works	The image suggests careful manners and hidden feeling. It gives the sound a texture.
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Now you try

Write three voices: a nervous teacher, an arrogant cousin and a kind stranger.

13. Hands: let action replace explanation

Plain English	Hands often tell the truth. A person can smile politely while their fingers pick, tap, crush, smooth, hide or hold on.
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The task	Describe a character's hands so the reader guesses the emotion.
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Model answer	While Auntie smiled, her fingers folded the napkin smaller and smaller until it looked punished.
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Why it works	The face says one thing; the hands reveal another. The napkin becomes a quiet clue.
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Now you try

Write four hand descriptions: impatience, shame, excitement and fear.

14. Clothes: turn appearance into biography

Plain English	Clothes should not be a shopping list. One item can tell us how a person lives, what they hide, or what they want others to believe.
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The task	Use one item of clothing to reveal a character's life.
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Model answer	His blazer remembered every place he had leaned, fallen, waited and pretended to be fine.
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Why it works	The blazer is worn, but it also holds a history of behaviour and feeling.
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Now you try

Describe one item: shoes, scarf, blazer, school bag, watch, tie or coat.

15. Weather around a person

Plain English	Roy often gives weather a human mood. In character writing, weather should press on the person or echo what they cannot say.
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The task	Let the weather sit close to a character's mood.
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Model answer	The heat stood behind Aunt Mira like a second temper.
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Why it works	The sentence keeps the person at the centre. The weather strengthens her mood instead of replacing her.
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Now you try

Describe a person walking into rain, heat, fog or wind. Make the weather reveal something about them.

16. Adults seen by children

Plain English	Children notice strange, funny and frightening details about adults. This is useful because a child's view can make a familiar person feel new.
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The task	Describe an adult through one sharp detail a child would notice.
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Model answer	Mr Harris was the sort of adult who smiled with his mouth and inspected you with his eyebrows.
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Why it works	The sentence is comic, but it also tells us he is watchful and not completely warm.
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Now you try

Write three adult portraits: a kind teacher, a suspicious neighbour and a dramatic aunt or uncle.

17. After bad news: ordinary things go strange

Plain English	A person after bad news may not announce their pain. They may become busy with tiny, ordinary actions. Those actions can be more moving than explanation.
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The task	Show a character after bad news through small actions and objects.
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Model answer	After the phone call, Mum became very busy with ordinary things: teaspoons, crumbs, the wrong cupboard.
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Why it works	The sentence never says she is upset. Her confusion appears in the objects she touches.
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Now you try

Write four lines about someone after bad news. Use ordinary objects, not dramatic declarations.

18. Place as a stage for a person

"The corridor stretched like a yawn nobody wanted to finish."

Original model image from the Oneiric Image Seeds pack

Plain English

This line is useful, but it is not the main event. Use setting as a stage that makes the person more memorable.

The task

Write one place image, then place a character inside it.

Model answer

The corridor stretched like a yawn nobody wanted to finish. At the far end stood Mina, clutching her bag with both hands.

Why it works

The corridor gives mood, but Mina gives the scene its human focus.

Now you try

Write two sentences: first a corridor, playground or dining room image; then a person inside it.

19. Final challenge: a memorable person

Plain English

For a longer answer, do not try to sound clever in every sentence. Use two or three strong images, then let the scene move.

The task

Choose one person: a new pupil, a secret-keeper, an arrogant cousin, a frightened teacher, a homesick friend or an adult with a childhood smile.

Model answer

Leila stood in the doorway with rain on her sleeves and another country folded behind her eyes. Her smile arrived late, careful and pale, as if it had been sent from far away.

Why it works

The description uses weather, eyes and smile, but it keeps the person at the centre.

Now you try

Write the opening eight to ten lines of a scene built around one memorable person.
